happening, Anjali and the gang had reached me. It was totally unexpected and I was deeply touched by the gesture.

Halfway through the Test, we found ourselves in a spot of bother. Centuries from Dravid and Dhoni had helped us to a decent first-innings total of 426, but Sri Lanka had scored 760 runs in response, thanks to hundreds from Dilshan and Prasanna Jayawardene and a double hundred from Mahela Jayawardene. We now needed to bat for a day and a half to save the game. But our never-say-die spirit came to the fore again and we batted exceptionally well to draw the match, with the opener Gambhir setting the foundation with 114.

I also scored a hundred on the last day and it was not a century free of incidents. Once it was evident to the Sri Lankans that they could no longer win, they set ultra-defensive fields. At one point Kumar Sangakkara, the Sri Lankan skipper, asked if I really wanted to carry on because there was no longer a possibility of a result in the match. I said to him bluntly that a Test hundred was a Test hundred and I would have got there long before if he had set sporting fields. While I had no problem with him trying to make things difficult for me, there was no reason for me to call it off when there was time left in the game.

At this, Sangakkara set a 7–2 off-side field and must have asked his left-arm fast bowler Welegedara to bowl to me a couple of feet outside my off stump with the ball going further away. I felt the need to improvise and on one occasion moved almost two feet outside the off stump and flicked Welegedara to square leg for four to get into the nineties. When I eventually reached my century, I asked Sangakkara if he wanted to continue the game. I was happy to carry on batting, but then we both decided to call off the game.

There was a similar situation in the same series during the third ODI in Cuttack on 21 December 2009. Chasing the Sri Lankan total of 239, I was in the nineties and Dinesh Karthik was giving me very good support at the other end. With only a few runs needed to win, Sangakkara decided to place most of his fielders on the boundary when I was facing, while for Dinesh he would bring the field right in. To counter the ploy, Dinesh played a number of dot-balls before I intervened and asked him just to finish the match. The win, I said, was far more important than my hundred. In the end, I remained unbeaten on 96 as Dinesh hit the winning runs.